


# THIS IS BAT COUNTRY

Drunk

Pilot

Written by

Kerry Ann Burke

Contact: kerry.ann.burke.screenwriter@gmail.com

(+353 089 218 0307)

Copyright (c) Kerry Ann Burke 2026
All Rights Reserved
WGA Registration - 2296100

AUGUST 2026 (v2.0)
SECOND DRAFT

**EXT. DYING MALL PARKING LOT - NIGHT**

Empty. Cracked asphalt under flickering sodium light. No cars except for a faded red minivan. No life.

They slam into frame-- CALEB (mid-20s, pale, off-kilter) wearing a faded, frayed denim jacket, fighting with JOSHUA (early-30s) wearing a polo and khakis. Joshua is covered in blood.

Joshua throws a punch--Caleb *catches* it, mid-air. Then--*Fangs*. *A hiss*.

He tosses Joshua into the red minivan. Joshua's eyes blow wide.

CALEB
(frustrated)
Yeah. Vampire. Didn't want to bury the lede.
(forceful)
Stay still, this'll be over quick.

Joshua, terrified, yells--equal parts pain and surprise.

But Caleb *stops*. His face twists in disgust, then he coughs, *violently, staggering into the van*.

CALEB (cont'd)
(choking)
Garlic breath? *Seriously?*

Joshua sees the opening, lands a right hook that dazes Caleb. A filled SYRINGE flies from his jacket pocket, skitters across the asphalt.

Joshua then bolts for the driver's seat while Caleb is startled. CLICK-CLICK. The van won't start. Joshua punches the wheel.

JOSHUA
(frantic)
No, no, no, no...

CALEB
(cough) Damn it. I'm gonna lose this guy to spaghetti aglio!

He checks his coat pocket. Empty.

CALEB (cont'd)
Oh, hell.

Caleb scans the asphalt. Broken glass. Oil rainbows. No syringe.

A *faint moan of pain* from inside the van. It stops Caleb cold. He abandons his search for the syringe and circles to the rear. Doors hang open.

Inside: a young woman. PANTS (24, bad nickname). Barely conscious. Wearing jeans, a faded Alice Cooper t-shirt, and most of her own blood.

Caleb winces in frustration, then scoops her into his arms--fast, but careful.

The engine sputters--finally turns over. Caleb looks at the van, then back at Pants.

CALEB
Stay with me, kid.

He checks her pulse. Already knows.

CALEB
Dammit, you are *not* staying with me, are you?

With her very last bit of strength, Pants flips Caleb the bird, then passes out, eyes open.

He scans the lot.

DUTCH ANGLE (diegetic film-noir voiceover) cuts in.

DUTCH ANGLE (V.O.)
Blew the job. Lost the mark.
Girl dying in my arms.
(beat)
Not my cleanest night.

Caleb grimaces at the girl in his arms.

CALEB
Oh, Angelina is going to *kill me* for this. And honestly? Fair.
(to Pants)
Sorry lady. I know I shouldn't be doing this...

He shakes his head, disgusted with himself.

CALEB (cont'd)
But I need answers.

He lowers his mouth to her neck--fangs sink in. Blood floods his mouth. Her heartbeat hammers--then slows.

Caleb pulls back, bites into his own wrist. Thick, dark blood wells up. He presses it to her lips. She swallows, reflexive.

Her head hangs loose in his arms--upside down. Her pupils fix on the license plate. Caleb doesn't see the plate--he has his hands (and fangs) full.

The van pulls away with a SCREECH. We cut to Joshua, panicking. He looks in the rear-view and sees Caleb holding Pants.

JOSHUA
(freaked out)
Vampires... *Vampires?*

**EXT. DYING MALL PARKING LOT - NIGHT - LATER**

The parking lot has become a crime scene. Cops and CSI are everywhere. Flooded with portable lights. We see the skidmarks left by Joshua's van when it pulled out.

Enter Detective WILCOX. (Early-30s) wearing a badge clipped to a lanyard. Dressed as if for a date. Product in hair.

A CSI tech gives him gloves, mask, shoe coverings and a hair net, and shows him a driver's license inside an evidence bag. It reads "ANTSEL, PATRICIA."

He sighs.

MOMENTS LATER

Wilcox crouches over the body, with a high-powered tactical flashlight. Pants is lying there. Dead.

WILCOX
(into recorder)
Patricia Antsel. Female, twenty-four. Multiple stab wounds. Defensive injuries. She fought.
(beat)
Good.

Shifts position. Keeps looking. A long, quiet moment.

WILCOX (cont'd)
Clustered. Same placement. Same depth... with hesitation.

A nearby CSI TECH shifts, uneasy.

He traces the air just above the wounds, not touching.

WILCOX (cont'd)
Stops. Starts again. Same spot. Didn't drift.

Wilcox straightens, already moving on. He shines the light over to the nearby asphalt. Scuff marks. Wilcox gestures for the tech.

WILCOX (cont'd)
Photo. With flash.

A CSI tech comes by and takes flash photography.

WILCOX (cont'd)
The shoe prints go toward and *away* from the tire marks. This wasn't a clean grab-and-go. That's *new*.

His flashlight passes over a crack in the asphalt. A glint.

He moves closer. In the crack, the SYRINGE. He stops. Doesn’t touch it. Just studies it.

WILCOX (cont'd)
Photo and bag that. Maybe a second actor. An accomplice... or interruption?

The CSI tech moves quickly.

MOMENTS LATER

We see Pants's body, covered in a sheet, carted away in a morgue transport. Wilcox watches it loaded into the ambulance.

**INT. HOSPITAL HALLWAY - NIGHT**

There's a sign posted that reads: "Morgue." It's dead quiet. Antiseptic. A security guard paces, going through his rounds. His shoes on the tile are the only sounds.

We follow him a moment. When he turns, we can see Caleb behind him. The guard doesn't see him.

Supernaturally swift, Caleb *lunges*--

A flash of fangs. A hand over the guard’s mouth.

SMASH CUT:

**INT. MORGUE - NIGHT**

A toe-tag. Attached to a woman's foot. It reads: "ANTSEL, PATRICIA -- F / 24"

Next: Pants's body, under a sheet, on a slab. No sound except fluorescent, sterile HUMMM of the lights.

FLASH CUTS OF HER MURDER: Grabbed. Thrown in a van. Masked man. Knife glints. Blood.

She gasps awake. Sits up. Disoriented. Blinking. She touches her chest, stomach, sides. Winces. There are bruises, not stab wounds.

Then hands fall on cold steel.

She clutches the sheet. Sees her toe tag. It takes her a moment to register the implication. Her breath hitches. Then--

**INT. HOSPITAL HALLWAY - NIGHT**

Her scream echoes faintly through the hallway. We see Caleb, leaning against a wall, carrying a stuffed backpack.

He looks down at the security guard, lying on the floor.

DUTCH ANGLE (V.O.)
I was stacking crime on top of crime, trying to Martingale my sins away.

Caleb rolls his eyes at the narration.

CALEB
(softly)
Will you shut up?

DUTCH ANGLE (V.O.)
I'd been living with the voice in my head long enough to know the answer was "no."
(beat)
And the more I screwed up, the more purple the prose.

Caleb closes his eyes. Just for a second. Then he starts walking, heading down the hallway back towards the morgue. He takes the backpack with him.

**INT. MORGUE - NIGHT**

Pants looks around, wild-eyed panic, furtive glances. Her eyes land on a chair nearby.

Folded purple (phlebotomy) scrubs. Hospital issue. A half-beat. She grabs them, desperately. We hear her putting them on. Too big.

Caleb enters. He moves slowly. Pants wobbles, woozy. Caleb halts.

CALEB
Not going to hurt you. Stay calm. You're probably feeling a little drunk.

PANTS
Drunk?

Caleb reaches into the backpack, pulls out a blood transfusion bag. He places it in Pants's hands. She looks at it with confusion.

CALEB
(beat)
Drink it. You'll feel better.

PANTS
That’s blood.

A beat.

CALEB
Yeah.

Silence. She looks at the bag. Then at Caleb. Recognition clicks.

PANTS
I remember you.
(beat)
You were there.

Now she steps toward him. Controlled. Focused.

PANTS (cont'd)
What the fuck did you do?

**INT. MORGUE FRONT DESK — NIGHT**

Wilcox leans against the wall, outside a door labeled "Coroner's Office." The CORONER steps out with a file folder in his hands, sipping a cup of coffee from a mug labeled "Embalming fluid." Coroner looks Wilcox up and down.

CORONER
Bit well dressed for a murder.

WILCOX
On a grindr date. Got stood up. Then got the call.

The coroner slides a file across. Already out. Wilcox notices.

WILCOX (cont'd)
You had that ready.

CORONER
Yeah. I did. Detective Wilcox... this is the third one this month.

**INT. MORGUE - NIGHT**

Caleb is still trying to emotionally wrangle Pants, as she's holding the blood bag in her hand.

PANTS
This is a prank, right? A viral thing? Like... influencers and fake... *morgues?*
(beat)
Is VampireTok a *thing?*

CALEB
It's not. Look, do me a favor. Just... sniff it. Humor me. Science experiment.

Pants lets out a scoff, but curiosity wins. She picks up the bag, tears the seal, lifts it to her nose.

WHAM -- her pupils blow wide. The world blurs, then snaps into razor clarity. Instinct takes over. She rips into the bag and drinks hard. Color seeps back into her skin. The bruises fade. Less corpse, more... something else.

She straightens, startled by the strength in her own body. Awe. Confusion. A beat.

Then--*terror*. Pants drops the empty bag. Backs up until she hits tile, breath ragged, eyes locked on Caleb.

Caleb steps back. Checks the door. The hallway. His wristwatch. Finally:

CALEB (cont'd)
Feeling better? A bit calmer?

PANTS
(in shock, understated)
You turned me into a vampire.

CALEB
That's *almost* not the important part. We have to move.

Pants looks at her hands--paler, maybe, but still hers.

PANTS
How? Why?

CALEB
Can we unpack the existential dread later?

PANTS
No. You don’t get to skip that.

CALEB
I'm not. I’m triaging.
(beat)
Don't want to get caught doing a felony. The blood’s a misdemeanor. Scrubs--petty larceny.
(automatic)
Under twelve hundred dollars, Nevada Revised Statutes two-oh-five--
(stops himself)
Not important. You don't want to stick around for the autopsy. Autopsy *bad*. We *go*.

A moment, as Pants realizes the implication.

PANTS
(scowling)
We're *not* done.

She *moves,* looking around the morgue. Her eyes track labels. Toe tags. Drawer numbers. Evidence bins.

PANTS (cont'd)
Where's my phone?

CALEB
In an evidence locker, presumably. Bigger priorities, though.

Caleb points to his watch.

CALEB (cont'd)
Sunrise is at 5:12 exactly, and sunlight is *bad*.

PANTS
How bad is *bad*?

CALEB
Charcoal briquette.

PANTS
Like... instantly?

CALEB
No. Plenty of time for screaming. On fire.

**INT. MORGUE HALLWAY - NIGHT**

Caleb and Pants head back out into the hallway. Caleb gestures her forward like a traffic cop. She sees the unconscious security guard. Immediately, she runs past Caleb over to him to check his health.

CALEB
(stage whisper)
Patricia!

She checks the guards pulse. Relief.

PANTS
He's got a pulse. Still breathing.

Pants checks her own pulse. Eyebrows raise.

PANTS (cont'd)
Jesus. I'm *not*.

CALEB
It eventually stops being weird.
Mostly.

She observes the guard, touches the back of his head, checks for injuries.

PANTS
No cuts, no bruises. No impact marks.
He didn’t fall. Someone lowered him.

CALEB
Of course I did. I'm not a monster.
(beat)
I'm not *that* kind of monster...
Usually.

PANTS
He's out cold. What happened to
him? Did you put him to sleep
with your... vampire powers?

Caleb opens a compartment of the backpack to show vials and syringes -- the syringes are identical to the SYRINGE he lost in the fight.

CALEB
If you consider ketamine to be a
*vampire power*, then yeah, sure.

PANTS
Oh.

He zips up the bag.

CALEB
You sound disappointed.

PANTS
It's just... thought it was mind control for a hot second.

A flicker of anger and regret on Caleb's face.

CALEB
I don't do mind control.

DUTCH ANGLE (V.O.)
I *could*. But I *don't*.

PANTS
You called me Patricia. How do you know my name?

CALEB
Read it off your toe-tag.

Pants is stunned. Caleb heads over to her and the guard, grabs her hand.

CALEB (cont'd)
I get it. This is all very overwhelming. But we *cannot* get caught here.
(sigh, beat)
I don’t want to play this card, but-- I am a vampire. A *very scary* vampire. You should be at least a little afraid.
(beat)
So--nicely--I’m threatening you. Please follow me.

A pause.

Pants punches him in the face. It shocks Caleb more than hurts him. She runs away from him, faster than she expects, through double-doors, nearly clipping a gurney.

Caleb, stunned, looks at the still swinging double doors.

DUTCH ANGLE (V.O.)
I didn't know why I thought that would work.

**INT. MORGUE FRONT DESK - NIGHT**

Pants is at a dead run, through the double doors of the hospital, where Wilcox and the coroner are still chatting.

Wilcox has his back to the doors, as Pants runs through. By the time he turns around, Pants is already through a second set of double doors and halfway down the hallway.

Caleb comes to the doors, peers through the glass, spots Wilcox.

He freezes, then panics and ducks back.

DUTCH ANGLE (V.O.)
Of course he was here. Wilcox.
(beat)
The kind of trouble that doesn't look like trouble until it's already got you in cuffs.
(long beat)
...wouldn't be the worst thing.

Caleb looks confused at that last beat.

Wilcox is staring at the doors where Pants just left.

WILCOX
Who was that?

CORONER
Purple scrubs. A phlebotomist.
(off Wilcox's look)
They draw blood.

WILCOX
Then what's she doing in the *morgue?*

Wilcox heads off in that direction, walking, not running.

Caleb heads back through the morgue hallway to find another exit. *He's* running.

**INT. HOSPITAL EMERGENCY ROOM - NIGHT**

The Hospital ER bustles with activity as Pants heads in. She looks around for someone, anyone who looks like an authority that can help her. She heads over to the NURSE ON DESK,

PANTS
I need he--

The outside doors SLAM open. An ambulance team barrels in with a *bleeding* gunshot victim.

PARAMEDIC #1
Gunshot! Move, move, move!

PARAMEDIC #2
He coded once in the ambulance, we got him back!

NURSE
How long down?

PARAMEDIC #2
Thirty seconds. Maybe forty.

PARAMEDIC #1
He needs a chest tube, like, yesterday!

Pants notices the blood flow... and can’t look away. Hungry. Pupils blown wide. Eyes open wider. Inhales like a stray dog finding a grill. Licks her lips.

This is *The Hungry Look*. Not romance. Not myth. Predatory. A thing she doesn’t know yet, but *will*.

She shakes her head. Something is off. She hears the sound of muffled heartbeats, all around her. Getting louder. Slowly drowning out every sound.

PARAMEDIC #1 (cont'd)
We’ve got arterial bleeding, don’t let him aspirate!

PARAMEDIC #2
Jesus, that’s a lot of blood--

Finally, the victim is wheeled away. Pants shivers and backs up a few steps. The heartbeats get softer, but aren't gone.

NURSE ON DESK
(to Pants)
Yeah. It's always like that here. Now, what can I help you with?

**EXT. HOSPITAL - NIGHT**

A glass liquor bottle lies shattered near the entrance.

Pants pushes past the doors, out into the night. The heartbeats fade. She turns back. Breathing hard. Not relief--just distance.

She steps back-- A shard bites into her foot.

PANTS
Ow! Dammit! Ow!

She hops over to a bench, sitting down. Glass lodged in her foot. The wound isn't bleeding.

She looks at it, winces. Then back at the ER. Shivers. No. Too dangerous. But she doesn't move.

CALEB (O.S.)
Patricia?

She looks over to the source of the sound. It's Caleb.

CALEB
Wanted to apologize. The threat thing? Dick move.

Caleb sits down next to her, slowly. Pants still eyes Caleb warily.

Then SLAPS him across the face. Hard.

Caleb rubs his face, then looks back at Pants.

CALEB (cont'd)
Seriously?

Pants momentarily looks guilty.

PANTS
I panicked.

Caleb points to her injured foot.

CALEB
I can help with that. *If* you want.

More hesitation. Finally, she trusts him with her foot.

PANTS
Don't do anything... wrong.

CALEB
I do a lot of things wrong, but I try to keep it to a minimum.

He pulls the glass out before she can brace. Pants hisses in pain. The wound heals up. Nearly instantly. (Like Wolverine.) Pants looks at it. Restrained reaction.

PANTS
Well, not that I'm not thankful, but I'm pretty sure wounds don't work like that.

Pants rubs her foot, while Caleb keeps scanning the environment.

CALEB
If that detective comes by, I might have to bolt, but you seem like you could use a breather. Figuratively.

Pants puts her head in her hands.

PANTS
I'm not bleeding. My heart's not beating... So. Cool. I'm going mental.

CALEB
If anyone's crazy here it's me.

DUTCH ANGLE (V.O.)
The hard-boiled detective voice in my head was Exhibit A.

Pants scoots away a little bit.

CALEB
Okay... yeah, that was not as reassuring as I meant it to be. I probably need therapy, is all I'm saying. But, good luck finding a shrink that works nights.

PANTS
(to self)
This can't be real.

CALEB
Patricia. Look at me.

She does. He tweaks her nose.

CALEB (cont'd)
*Honk*.
(beat)
Real enough?

Silence. Her fight-or-flight glitches. The disarming weirdness of the nose-tweak shocks her. The fear's not gone, but it short-circuits.

PANTS
Who the hell are you?

CALEB
I'm Caleb. Caleb Tryst.

Caleb offers a handshake. Pants doesn't take it. A long beat.

Then finally, Pants *snorts*.

PANTS
Caleb Tryst.
(a beat)
Caleb *Tryst?*

Caleb looks away, annoyed.

CALEB
Yes.

PANTS
As in... an illicit sexual liaison?

CALEB
...yes.

PANTS
That's... wow, that's a hell of a name.
(beat)
Oh my god. That's like a vampire's *drag name*.

CALEB
(nerve hit)
Shut up.

She looks back at the ER.

PANTS
Do we have time for questions *now?*

CALEB
One or two.

PANTS
How do you keep... *it* under control?

Caleb reaches into his backpack, pulls out another transfusion bag, hands it to her.

She looks at it, takes it, stares at it for a little while.

CALEB
They're kind of like big Capri-Suns, aren't they?

**INT. MORGUE HALLWAY - NIGHT**

Staff wheel the unconscious guard past.

Wilcox is standing in the doorway, next to the coroner, looking at the morgue. We don't see what we're looking at yet.

They look at each other. Neither is amused.

Wilcox takes out a cellphone and dials.

WILCOX
Ritter, sorry to wake you. I think you should come down to the morgue at UNLV Medical Center.

RITTER (V.O.)
Did you find anything?

WILCOX
Find something? No.

We pull back. We see the plastic sheet, empty blood bag... and no body.

WILCOX (cont'd)
In fact... the opposite.

**EXT. HOSPITAL PARKING LOT - NIGHT**

Pants follows Caleb through the parking lot, this time with cheap hospital sandals -- the kind for patients who have come in without shoes.

Caleb stops suddenly. Winces. Looks back at the hospital.

Pants looks at him.

CALEB
The morgue footage--I was going to wipe it.
(beat)
When you ran, I lost the chance. Wilcox probably has it by now.

PANTS
Wilcox?

CALEB
Detective. Homicide. He and his partner are bad news.

PANTS
Can't you wipe it remotely?

CALEB
No.
(genuine)
Unless you know how to do that.

PANTS
No.
(beat)
How bad is that? On a scale of one to ten?

CALEB
Eh, about a five.
(too casual)
I'll deal with it later.

DUTCH ANGLE (V.O.)
It was a nine point eight, and I had no idea what to do about it.

They arrive at Caleb's *Cursed Camry*, a 1998 Toyota Camry that looks every bit three decades old. Mismatched tires. Dents. Scratches. Neglect. It looks more undead than the vampires do.

CALEB
Is there anything I can do or say that'll get you into a car with a strange man you just met?

Pants raises an eyebrow.

PANTS
In *that* car? No. It looks haunted.

She peers in the window. Exposed wires. Screwdriver in the ignition.

PANTS (cont'd)
It looks *stolen*.

CALEB
A/C's busted, too.

Caleb leans against the trunk, and sighs.

PANTS
You *really* didn't think this whole making a vampire thing through, did you?

Frustration at his own incompetence seeps into Caleb's voice.

CALEB
No. No I did not.

**INT. MORGUE FRONT DESK - NIGHT**

UNIFORMED OFFICERS and a CSU TECH work the scene.

TECH
...we dusted, the morgue doors and the slab. Nothing. No oils. No ridges. Nada.

OFFICER
Were they wearing gloves?

TECH
Haven't found any.

The coroner comes in, with a copy of Pants's file, heads straight to Wilcox.

CORONER
Wilcox. Just noticed something.

Peter looks at the file. The coroner points.

CORONER (cont'd)
Antsel's medical records say O negative. What we pulled? AB positive.

Wilcox looks at the work.

WILCOX
Son of a bitch. Yeah, get the rest of that down to the lab for DNA testing.

CORONER
But... what does that mean?

WILCOX
Nothing yet. Could be the attacker's blood type. Could be contamination.

RITTER (O.S.)
Could also mean the victim was incorrectly identified.

Detective RITTER (late 60s) steps in. Rumpled coat. Coffee-stained tie. The look of a man who has slept poorly for decades.

WILCOX
Ritter. Sorry for waking you up late.

RITTER
I'd be more upset if you didn't. Got security footage?

Wilcox frowns.

WILCOX
I asked for it, but everything's just obsolete enough to be a pain in the ass. Budget cuts. The video quality is potato.

RITTER
The quality is what?

WILCOX
...bad. It's bad.
(beat)
We're grabbing it, but it might not hold up in court. In the morning, when their one tech wakes up, he'll burn it to a DVD.

RITTER
(incensed)
*Burn it to a--*

He sighs.

RITTER (cont'd)
Wilcox, promise me something.

WILCOX
What's that?

RITTER
If I ever have to get a major surgery? Drive me to California.

**EXT. HOSPITAL PARKING LOT - NIGHT**

Pants and Caleb are not in the car, but Pants and Caleb are leaning on the trunk together.

PANTS
So, what's your deal?

CALEB
You want the lore dump *now?* Can't we wait until we're someplace less exposed for the exposition?

PANTS
No. I have absolutely no reason to trust you. I want answers before I get into a stolen car with a strange man I just met.

CALEB
Makes sense. You don't want to get murdered twice in one night.

Pants glares.

CALEB (cont'd)
Too soon?

Pants glares harder.

CALEB (cont'd)
Patricia?

Pants grunts in frustration.

PANTS
Can you not call me that?

CALEB
"Patricia?"

PANTS
Yeah. It’s a stupid name. Only my grandmother uses it--and we do not get along.

CALEB
Okay. What should I call you?

PANTS
My friends call me Pants.

Caleb blinks, shakes his head.

PANTS (cont'd)
High school e-mail address. P.ANTSEL became PANTSEL became Pants.

CALEB
You were just on my case about *my* name.

PANTS
Deservedly. And what's with the Canadian Tuxedo?

Caleb looks away, annoyed by the question.

CALEB
It's... sentimental. It's the only thing from... before.

This actually triggers regret from Pants.

PANTS
Oh. Sorry.

Caleb looks away, deep sigh. Then continues:

CALEB
That, and a Blockbuster card with my livename on it.

Pants tilts her head.

PANTS
*Blockbuster?* Jesus. Exactly when was your... *Embrace into Darkness*?

CALEB
Excuse me?

PANTS
Your... Dark Baptism?
(beat)
*Envampification?*

CALEB
Nineteen ninety eight.

Pants shakes her head, frustrated at the absurdity.

PANTS
Well, that explains the Lost Boys cosplay.
(beat)
I vaguely remember flipping you off as I was dying.

CALEB
You did. Badass way to go out, actually. Like a movie.

Pants looks away, tries to hide her proud smirk.

In the background, multiple cop cars drive into the parking lot, sirens blaring, and *past* Caleb and Pants. Caleb looks at them with alarm.

CALEB (cont'd)
I have to go. *Now*. You're my best lead to finding your killer. I'm your best shot at getting through this.

PANTS
Still don't trust you.

CALEB
(exasperated)
I know. But who do you trust more? Me... or the cops?

**INT. CALEB'S CURSED CAMRY - NIGHT**

Caleb is driving the car up the I-15. Pants is sitting in the passenger seat, staring out the window.

CALEB
Want the radio?

PANTS
I think I just need to sit. If that's alright.

Caleb swallows. Eyes on the road.

There's a deep THUMP-THUMP-THUMP sound. Pants is startled by it.

PANTS (cont'd)
Oh my god, is there *someone in the trunk?*

CALEB
*Shit*. Not now.

The wheel pulls to one side, Caleb pulls the car over. It sits slightly lopsided.

**EXT. ROADSIDE - NIGHT**

Caleb and Pants look at the flat rear tire. Passing cars whoosh by. Headlights wash over them. Their shadows stretch across the asphalt -- long, skeletal.

Caleb glances east. The horizon is still dark. Not as dark as before. He looks at his watch, shows it to Pants, nods to himself.

CALEB
Not great, but we've still got time.

Pants lets out a quiet, bitter laugh.

CALEB (cont'd)
What is it?

PANTS
I'm actually a *fan*. Of the genre.

CALEB
The genre?

PANTS
Vampire genre. Movies. TV. Novels.
(beat)
Used to write fanfic. Not proud of all of it.
(beat)
Okay. Some of it.
(beat)
*Shut up*.

Caleb chuckles.

PANTS (cont'd)
And here you are. Vampire. With a flat.

Caleb pops the trunk, starts getting out the donut.

CALEB
You're right. The movies don't do the glamorous vampire life justice.

Pants grabs the scissor jack and the lug wrench, propping up the car without prompting. The jack sinks slightly into the gravel. Pants stabilizes it.

Caleb takes the lug wrench. We see rusted lug nuts.

PANTS
Need me to brace the--

Caleb tightens his grip. CRACK. Vampire strength.

PANTS (cont'd)
Oh.

CALEB
Thanks, though.

Caleb continues to change the tire, they work and talk, Pants handing over the donut when he gestures for it.

PANTS
After the tire, what happens? You take me to the vampire king of Vegas or something?

CALEB
Vampire *king?*

PANTS
In the books, there's always politics. Kings, secret societies...

Caleb breaks into a full throated laugh.

CALEB
What? No. *Stop*. Vampires don't do that.
(beat)
No masquerade balls. No velvet thrones. Just survival. Nobody has time for titles.

While they work, a police cruiser passes slowly. Caleb lowers his head. Pants freezes. The cruiser doesn't stop. Moves on.

The night returns. Highway hiss. Somewhere distant, a siren Dopplers away.

PANTS
What about *your* sire? The one who vamped *you?*

CALEB
Don't know what happened to him. Don't even know who he is.

Caleb loads the flat tire into the back seat (not the trunk.)

DUTCH ANGLE (V.O.)
I'd been chasing that question for years. And somehow, a girl who walked
(MORE)

DUTCH ANGLE (V.O.) (cont'd)
into the wrong vampire story paid for it.

CALEB
Kind of a sore spot.

**INT. HOSPITAL SECURITY ROOM - NIGHT**

A beat cop stands in the background. Wilcox at the controls. Ritter over his shoulder, peering at the screens.

WILCOX
You sure you don't want to wait for the tech?

RITTER
I'm not waiting for tomorrow. I want to see what we have now.

Wilcox scrolls through feeds.

Ritter peers at the small screens, squinting.

RITTER (cont'd)
If you see something I miss, point it out. I'm an old man. I shouldn't be up this late.

Wilcox inhales sharply. He jolts upright--eyes locked on one monitor.

WILCOX
You're not the only one who's not supposed to be up, Ritter.

Ritter frowns. Steps closer.

On the monitor: SECURITY FOOTAGE. Grainy. Washed-out. Almost black and white.

A woman in hospital scrubs -- Pants -- moving under her own power.

Then, just at the edge of frame: A man in a faded denim jacket.

Ritter goes still--recognition, then disbelief.

The image jitters. Caleb’s face is never fully clear. But the jacket is unmistakable.

RITTER
...pause that.

Wilcox does. The frame freezes -- imperfect, incomplete.

Ritter leans in. His breath catches despite himself.

He doesn’t say the name. Not yet.

WILCOX
Ritter?

RITTER
Put out an APB. Description only. Assume Denim Jacket is dangerous. I think the girl’s a hostage.

WILCOX
You recognize him?

RITTER
Maybe. There's an old file I need to pull. If I'm wrong, it's nothing. If I'm right...

He leans in, raps on the monitor with a knuckle. (Recurring motif.)

RITTER (cont'd)
If I'm right... *it's impossible*.

**EXT. ABANDONED INDUSTRIAL PARK - NIGHT**

Post-boom, pre-bulldozer. Cracked asphalt. Silent buildings. The Mojave night is quiet--punctuated by insects and wind dragging dry grass.

Caleb parks in a faded spot, gets out. Opens the passenger side door for Pants, then runs round the back to get his backpack.

Caleb pulls out a single key from his pocket. No ring. No chain. A life reduced to one lock.

CALEB
Pardon the mess.
(beat)
It’s reflective of my mental state.

His voice echoes faintly off the empty buildings.

Pants gets out of the car. Scans the lot. She’s uneasy now--adrenaline fading, reality creeping in.

Wind drags a sheet of plastic across cracked asphalt.

PANTS
This is a bad idea.

CALEB
What is?

PANTS
Following you. In there.

Caleb pauses.

CALEB
Yeah, it would be, wouldn't it? Very "don't go into the basement" energy.

PANTS
More like: Nuclear waste burial site, do not approach, this is not a place of honor, nothing of value is buried here vibes.

He looks at his watch.

CALEB
Counterpoint...

He gestures to the building like a game show model showing off a consolation prize.

CALEB (cont'd)
*This* has no windows. Which is ninety-nine percent of what you're looking for in vampire real estate.

Pants still eyes it warily.

PANTS
Right. But... you're a vampire. I go in there... what's stopping you from eating me?

CALEB
Already did.

PANTS
What?

CALEB
The turning. That's how it works. I drank your blood. All of it. Well, what was left of it. Then I gave you some of mine.

PANTS
Oh, like in...

CALEB
Exactly. One thing the books actually got right. Point is, I already ate you, Pants.
(MORE)

CALEB (cont'd)
(beat)
Eating you again is like... vampire backwash.

PANTS
Oh.

Silence. Processing.

PANTS (cont'd)
So when you said I was "drunk" before, you meant...

CALEB
Yeah. I drank you.

More processing. Pants frowns.

PANTS
Was I... tasty?

She immediately winces, regretting it.

PANTS (cont'd)
...wow. Did not need to ask that.

Caleb snickers.

CALEB
"Antsel Lite. Tastes Great, Less Filling."
(beat)
Sorry. That was dumb.

In the distance a COYOTE HOWLS. Uncanny. Almost laughing. Almost screaming.

Pants shivers.

PANTS
Great. I get the full "music of the children of the night" treatment.

CALEB
Oh yeah. The coyotes. They get louder near dawn.

Caleb turns the key. The lock clicks open.

He holds the door -- not asking. Just... ready.

CALEB (cont'd)
If it makes a difference, I've got *Tetris*.

PANTS
*Tetris*?

CALEB
Helps with shock and trauma.
(beat)
The not-screaming tipped me off to the shock part. Trauma's a given.

She gives him a look, then evaluates the open door. Then at the empty lot behind her.

Another howl answers the first. Then another. Louder than before.

She looks back at the car. At the empty road beyond. The wind lifts dust across the asphalt. Nothing coming. Nothing waiting. Nothing follows.

She steps inside.

**INT. CALEB'S INDUSTRIAL PARK HAVEN - NIGHT**

Caleb flicks on the lights. Fluorescent. Cold. Nothing could live here. Technically, nothing does. He places the backpack down on a counter, near a mini-fridge.

Pants scans the room. Half *dumpster-chic*, half *stolen-from-a-dead-grandma's-house* while her grieving family was at the funeral.

Clothes strewn everywhere. A bare mattress with an army blanket. On the floor: battered noir/detective paperbacks & DVDs.

A couch that's seen better days. A ragged chair. A CRT TV with combo VHS/DVD player. An 8-bit console with one controller.

There's a *murder wall*. Clippings. Crime scene photos. Some from the 90s. Red string. Post-it notes.

PANTS
You have a *murder wall?*

CALEB
Oh--right. One sec.

He jogs over, scrawls *PATRICIA "PANTS" ANTSEL* on a post-it, and sticks it on the wall.

PANTS
You couldn't have *waited* to do that?
(grunt)
I wasn't expecting *'Live, Laugh, Love'* decor from a vampire haven, but this is--

CALEB
Dead, Dread, Diagram? Fair.

Caleb looks around at the sorry state of how he lives.

CALEB (cont'd)
Look, uh, you can have the mattress. I'll take the couch. If you get hungry, there's bloodbags in the fridge. Tomorrow... I don't know. Maybe get you some real clothes at a thrift store.

PANTS
A thrift store?

CALEB
Money's tight right now.
(beat)
No. Better idea. I should introduce you to Angelina. She could help.

PANTS
A friend?

CALEB
More of an ex...

Pants rolls her eyes. Caleb slumps down on the couch. Thinker pose.

PANTS
Right. Spill it.

CALEB
Spill what?

DUTCH ANGLE (V.O.)
She was too sharp to be strung along like a puppy on a leash. Smart. Quick enough to make my life hell.
(beat)
I liked her.

PANTS
I don't get you. Sometimes it feels like you have no idea what you're doing. And other times it's like you've planned everything.
(beat)
So which is it?
(beat)
I mean, what was the point in saving my life if you're not going to let me live it? Did you just want to preserve my witness testimony?

He doesn't answer. But he hangs his head. An admission of guilt.

A beat.

DUTCH ANGLE (V.O.)
And here it came. Three. Two. One...

PANTS
(realization)
Oh...

DUTCH ANGLE (V.O.)
(dry)
Kaboom.

PANTS
Great.

Caleb looks away from her. At the murder wall.

CALEB
You're the only one who can help me stop this, Pants. *That's* why I turned you.

PANTS
How?

CALEB
Maybe you remember something that leads me to him. Or there are... other ways.

PANTS
What ways?

Caleb puts his hand to his temple, and rubs. A stress headache.

CALEB
I don't know yet. There are people we could ask.

PANTS
Who, the cops?

CALEB
Not the cops. If people found out that vampires were real--living among them--We'd be crucified.
(beat)
Possibly literally.

Pants raises an eyebrow at that. She sighs.

PANTS
Okay. Not the cops. Maybe one of my friends? When can I see them again?

CALEB
You can't. You'll get them killed.

PANTS
What about my blackjack dealer training course? I already paid six hundred dollars.

Caleb shoots her a look.

CALEB
Your new vocation is "vampire." Hours are sunset to sunrise, and the pay sucks.
(beat)
Is there anyone who'd come looking for you?

PANTS
Come again?

CALEB
Anyone who's going to notice you're gone? Family. Lover. Anyone you owe money to?

Pants doesn't answer right away. It hits her hard.

PANTS
Friends, maybe, but... nobody like that.
(shaken)
Wow. I just realized no one is going to mourn me.

A moment of silence.

CALEB
I'm sorry. But it makes things safer.

Pants shoots Caleb a disapproving look.

PANTS
Anything else?

CALEB
I smelled garlic on him.
(beat)
Made me miss Italian food.

Pants raises her eyebrows at the seeming non-sequitur.

PANTS
What?

CALEB
No coffee, no alcohol, no food. It doesn't digest. And it doesn't taste right.

PANTS
What does it taste like?

CALEB
To paraphrase Nick Offerman, like the food your food eats. And I miss it.

The fluorescent lights buzz overhead.

Pants sits down on the other end of the couch. Closer, but still distant.

PANTS
Sounds rough.

CALEB
It is. I don't know what to tell you, Pants. I know how to keep us alive. Everything else? I'm out of practice.

DUTCH ANGLE (V.O.)
This was as good a time as any to start practicing again.

PANTS
Okay. For *now*, you get the benefit of the doubt. But I'm not your sidekick.

CALEB
Vampires don't have sidekicks. You're thinking of Batman.

PANTS
I mean it. I'm only sticking with you because you know more about being a vampire than I do... and I want to catch my killer.

Caleb nods once.

A long, uncomfortable pause.

Caleb shrugs, then gestures to the 8-bit console, grabbing a controller, handing it to her without looking directly at her.

CALEB
*Tetris?*

Pants takes the controller. She then looks at the murder wall.

Caleb heads over to the CRT TV and turns it on. It boots up with a ghostly whine. He then goes over to the 8-bit console. "*Castlevania II*" out. "*Tetris*" in. He turns the console on.

Pants looks back at the TV. The blocks are already falling.

She sighs, and says:

PANTS
...fine.

She leans forward, slightly.

**EXT. LAS VEGAS STRIP - DAWN**

Sunrise over the Strip. Neon dies.

SUPER: The Morning Sun Has Vanquished The Horrible Night.

**EXT/INT. THE VENETIAN - DAY**

Establishing. Luxury. Tourists taking selfies beneath a painted sky. Gondolas glide through chlorinated canals.

**INT. CANALETO RISTORANTE - DAY**

Joshua, putting on chef's whites. Clean. Pressed. Like nothing happened.

But he flinches at every clatter. Every voice behind him. Not cool. Not controlled. He begins chopping garlic at his prep station.

A LINE COOK walks up.

COOK (O.S.)
You look like hell, man.

Joshua jumps. Drops the knife. Everyone looks--then goes back to work.

JOSHUA
I... didn't sleep last night.

The cook gathers peeled garlic from his station.

COOK
Again? Maybe you should talk to someone.

JOSHUA
I've tried. But I can't.

In the background, hotel staff unload crates of vegetables. Joshua’s eyes spot a SACK OF GARLIC.

COOK
Whatever. Watch the blades. We're already short-staffed.

Joshua's eyes stay on the garlic.

**INT. VENETIAN PARKING GARAGE — DAY**

Joshua returns to his red Ford Econoline. His whites now splattered with sauce and grease. He places the stolen SACK OF GARLIC in the passenger seat. Gently buckles it in. Starts the van. Drives off.

**EXT. ABANDONED INDUSTRIAL PARK — DUSK**

Establishing. The sun is going down.

SUPER: What A Horrible Night To Have A Curse.

**INT. CALEB'S INDUSTRIAL PARK HAVEN - NIGHT**

Pants stirs on Caleb's mattress. She sits up slowly. Caleb, a denim-wrapped lump on the couch, hasn’t even taken off his shoes. He rises. Stretches. Doesn’t yawn.

CALEB
Evening, Pants. How you feeling?

She scans the room, still foggy.

PANTS
Terrified.

CALEB
Other than that.

PANTS
A little hungry. You don't have like, a cereal bar or--

Pants stops in shock as she realizes it's not *cereal bars* she's hungry for. Caleb heads over to the minifridge.

CALEB
Sorry. I'm a vampire. Only have blood.

He pulls out a blood bag and hands it to her.

CALEB (cont'd)
If you want a cereal bar, try a serial killer.

Pants shoots him a withering glare.

PANTS
Caleb. You turned me into a *vampire* last night. Now is not the time for *dad jokes*.

CALEB
Sorry, it's my main coping mechanism.

PANTS
Is it working?

CALEB
No. Not really.

Pants leans against the wall. Sips from the bag.

DUTCH ANGLE (V.O.)
“Coping.” Cute word. Truth was uglier. I was falling apart faster than my car. Running on empty. Brakes gone.
(beat)
Check engine light on. Nobody home.

PANTS
Wait. Just--wait.

Still shaken, but no longer in a full panic.

PANTS (cont'd)
I have questions. And you have answers.

CALEB
True.

PANTS
First question. Why are you doing this? The whole...

She gestures to the murder wall.

CALEB
Your killer's bringing the wrong kind of attention, for one.

PANTS
Fair enough, but why do *you* have to go after him? Why not leave him for the police?
(beat)
You check your watch constantly for sunrise. You're always looking over your shoulder for the cops. And *yet*, you're risking an awful lot just to catch *one guy*.
(beat)
This is *personal* for you, isn't it?

CALEB
Okay, yeah. It is. It is personal.

PANTS
So, what is it? What's your connection to these killings?

CALEB
That's personal.

Pants narrows her eyes.

CALEB (cont'd)
Yeah, I know. But... look, forget that. There's a pattern here, one the cops won't get.

Caleb goes over to the murder wall, gestures broadly with his whole arm over the modern victims section.

CALEB (cont'd)
You and the other two girls, you were all murdered in the past month. Same method. Similar victims.

Pants nods, following along. Caleb then takes a step to the left, and gestures to a different section, tapping on a date in April 1998.

CALEB (cont'd)
*These* murders happened in the late 90s. Similar M.O. and victims.

Caleb frowns, lip trembling as he looks at the 90s victims. Pants doesn't see it.

PANTS
A killer who reappears every thirty years. Where have I seen that before? Have you called Stephen King?

CALEB
I did. But he has a solid alibi.

Pants takes a half-step back, then leans back in.

CALEB (cont'd)
Point is, this is supernatural. Or close enough. And... the cops aren't equipped for that. If I -- if *we* -- don't stop this, it doesn't stop.

Pants pauses. Considers it.

PANTS
Well, at least now I know the stakes.
(beat)
Speaking of... stakes. Do they kill us?

CALEB
Never found out. Hope I never have to.

PANTS
Oh. Mirrors?

CALEB
We show up in mirrors, photos, security cameras, digital cameras, all of that. Unless it's a really old mirror, one that's backed by silver. Then, no reflection. Don't know why.

PANTS
The first vampire. Dracula?

CALEB
I think he's fiction.

PANTS
You *think* he's fiction.
(beat)
You really don't have a whole lot of answers, do you?

CALEB
Sorry, I never got issued the vampire handbook. Everything I know came from trial and error.

PANTS
What about garlic?

Caleb frowns.

CALEB
No. That one's just me.

Pants raises a finger, confused, narrowing her eyes. Before she speaks:

CALEB (cont'd)
Other vampires deal with it just fine. But not me. My personal kryptonite.
(beat)
If your attacker hadn't been binging garlic knots, I would've--

Pants starts to get woozy, dizzy, she leans heavily on the couch's armrest.

A flash of RED. The hum of the mini-fridge swells.

Caleb notices Pants is not alright.

CALEB (cont'd)
Pants?

PANTS
Oh god... Yeah. I remember the garlic breath... the oil... like pizza boxes left in a hot car.

Caleb frowns.

CALEB
Flashback. Sorry.

PANTS
I don't-- this is too much, Caleb. I can't handle this.

Silence. There's no answer. Finally:

CALEB
Would you like to learn how to restart a hotwired car?

Pants tilts her head, skeptical, but intrigued.

**EXT. LVMPD BUILDING - NIGHT**

The Cursed Camry rolls up. The LVMPD building looms in the distance. Pants is driving.

**EXT./INT. CALEB'S CURSED CAMRY - NIGHT**

Caleb checks his watch.

CALEB
Okay. It's 8:16 P.M. Would you mind going over the plan one more time?

Pants sighs.

PANTS
Take the car. Orleans Casino. Don't go in. Wait for you. If you're not there by 10:30 on the dot, go to the poker room and page "Angelina Nuit." She'll help me.

CALEB
And if you can't find Angelina?

PANTS
Leave a note for her. Head back to the haven.

CALEB
And if you can't get back to the haven?

PANTS
Las Vegas Storm Drains. Last resort.

CALEB
And the most important part?

Pants rolls her eyes.

PANTS
Don't contact anyone I used to know or go back to my old apartment.

CALEB
Especially that.
(emphasis)
Do *not* contact anyone you know. Do *not* go back to your old apartment.
(beat)
And the second most important part?

PANTS
Try not to kill anyone.

Caleb moves to get out--stops. Freezes. Looks back.

CALEB
I hate leaving you on your own, but...

PANTS
Caleb. You're the one that keeps saying the clock's ticking.

CALEB
Right.

Caleb looks out at the police building. Takes a nervous breath. Looks back at Pants.

Then back to the building.

CALEB (cont'd)
*Right*.

He finally gets out of the car.

He gets two steps towards the door, and then turns back to Pants.

CALEB (cont'd)
Oh, Pants, I forgot to tell you...

But Pants has already driven off. Like she can't wait to be free of him.

Caleb turns back to the police station.

CALEB (cont'd)
Never mind. I'm sure it wasn't important.

**INT. LVMPD BUILDING (OUTER HALLWAYS) - NIGHT**

Caleb takes a folded baseball cap from his jacket and puts it on, obscuring his face. He looks around. A janitor most nearby. Caleb watches him closely.

The janitor finishes, dumps the bucket, locks the closet, and walks off. He locks it with a single key, but it's a simple lock.

Caleb waits for him to leave, looks around. When the coast is clear, he takes out a ring of *bump keys* from the jacket, finds one and checks it in the light.

Caleb inserts the bump key into the lock, then gives the lock a swift bump. The door opens.

CALEB
(sotto)
Thank you, lock-picking lawyer.

He steps inside. Moments later, he’s back out--jumpsuit, mop, bucket.

**EXT. PANTS'S APARTMENT - NIGHT**

Pants, defying Caleb, heads up to a third floor walk-up apartment. She grabs a hide-a-key from a fake cactus. She unlocks the door.

An unmarked Crown Vic sits parked nearby.

We don't follow Pants as she heads inside. We follow the Crown Vic. Ritter and a neighbor approach, talking. Ritter is casual, drinking coffee.

Ritter hands the neighbor a business card.

RITTER
...and if Ms. Antsel comes back this way, give her my contact information. It's important. She's not in trouble, we just want to make sure she's alright.

The neighbor nods and walks off.

Ritter moves to get into the Crown Vic when the third floor apartment light comes on.

He almost misses it. Double-takes.

RITTER (cont'd)
Son of a bitch.

**INT. PANTS'S APARTMENT - NIGHT**

It's an efficiency apartment. Assembled IKEA furniture. Unassembled life. Functional, not personal. A movie poster tacked on the walls with blu-tack. Desk/table that doubles as everything.

Kitchenette. Microwave. Hot plate. Mismatched set of mugs. Protein bars. Cheap coffee.

Blackjack dealer work-clothes hung up neatly, rest of the clothes in a laundry basket, full.

Bed pushed against the wall - a twin.

Almost as soon as she gets through the door, she collapses face down on the bed, exhausted.

PANTS
(muffled)
Fuuuuuuuu...

She flips over, gets up. Starts getting changed out of the scrubs.

**EXT. PANTS'S APARTMENT - NIGHT - CONTINUOUS**

Ritter is slowly walking up the stairwell, casual, unhurried. We hear the STAIRS SQUEAK.

**INT. PANTS'S APARTMENT - NIGHT - CONTINUOUS**

Pants, now dressed in a t-shirt and jeans, hears the creaking of the stairs and Ritter's footsteps. Her head snaps up.

She gets up, slowly, carefully. Grabs a tote bag, starts stealthily gathering essentials, starting with underwear.

The FOOTSTEPS get louder. Closer. Joined by a HEARTBEAT - Ritter's.

A KNOCK at the door. Too loud. Her head whips around to the door in a panic.

RITTER
Ms. Antsel? This is Detective Ritter with the Las Vegas Metropolitan Police Department? You're not in trouble, but mind if I ask you a few questions?

**INT. LVMPD BUILDING (INNER HALLWAYS) - NIGHT**

Caleb moves through the LVMPD hallway pushing a mop bucket, head low, eyes scanning.

Footsteps approach. Wilcox rounds the corner, on his cellphone.

Caleb sees him first. Freezes.

WILCOX
(on phone)
...so you’re telling me it’s not unheard of for someone to be declared dead at scene and then just walk out of the morgue?

Wilcox passes in front of Caleb, blocking him from view.

He stops. A flicker of recognition. He turns.

Now Caleb has his head down, mopping. Wilcox studies him.

WILCOX (cont'd)
(on phone)
Hold on a sec, Janice.
(beat, gently)
Hey.

Caleb keeps mopping.

WILCOX (cont'd)
(a little firmer)
Hey.

Caleb freezes. Has he been made?

WILCOX (cont'd)
(broken Spanish)
Mi amigo. Buen trabajo. Perdón por mi español. Estoy aprendiendo.

SUBTITLE: My friend. Good job. Forgive my Spanish. I'm learning.

Caleb hesitates, then nods.

CALEB
(broken Spanish)
Gracias, Detective Wilcox. Usted es muy guapo y encantador.

SUBTITLE: Thank you, Detective Wilcox. You are very handsome and charming.

Wilcox blinks once. Processing. Professional face returns.

Caleb keeps his eyes on the mop. Finally:

WILCOX
(broken Spanish)
Uh... gracias... usted también.

SUBTITLE: Uh... thank you... you too.

Wilcox nods, smiling. After a tense beat, he goes back to his call.

WILCOX (cont'd)
(on phone)
Sorry about that, Janice. Had a chance to practice my Spanish and show some love to the custodian. So what do you think?
(pause)
Your best guess is hypothermia?
(beat)
Janice... it's Las Vegas.
(beat)
In August.

Wilcox turns the corner.

Caleb exhales and moves past him.

DUTCH ANGLE (V.O.)
The ol' high school Spanish gambit. Truly, I was a criminal genius.

**INT. LVMPD BUILDING - EVIDENCE AREA - NIGHT**

Caleb finally reaches the evidence area. He passes by the desk, where an EVIDENCE COP is sitting, reading a dog-eared magazine. He doesn't look up. Just turns the page.

Caleb swipes a loose evidence tag from the desk, then turns the corner. Checks the hallway. Then he makes some scribbles on it with a pen he pulls out of his boiler suit -- fast, not neat.

He loops the tag around his left leg. Ties it on.

BACK TO: The EVIDENCE COP, still engrossed in his magazine. Heavy sigh.

CLATTER--a wooden baseball bat hits the ground. He moves to check it out.

He looks at the ground. An abandoned mop. A bucket. A crumpled jumpsuit in the corner. And a wooden baseball bat with an evidence tag on it. It's been stained blue.

*Denim* blue.

**INT. LVMPD BUILDING (EVIDENCE LOCKER) - NIGHT**

The Evidence Cop places the blue bat inside the locker. Locks it.

DUTCH ANGLE (V.O.)
Lots of vampires turn into bats.

The bat... shifts. Warps.

DUTCH ANGLE (V.O.) (cont'd)
I just got creative with it.

Caleb unfolds out of it.

**INT. PANTS'S APARTMENT - NIGHT**

Pants is frozen in fear. Another knock.

RITTER
Ms. Antsel? Are you there?

Pants opens her mouth to answer... and *almost* does. She then spots something on the desk. Almost hidden among various coffeeshop punch cards and casino gamer club cards, shopping receipts, and bits of lint and loose change.

A red laminated card: KNOW YOUR RIGHTS.

Pants looks back at the door, and grits her teeth.

**INT. PANTS'S APARTMENT (BATHROOM) - NIGHT**

Pants carries a stuffed totebag and slips into the bathroom. She stands on the toilet and opens the bathroom window.

RITTER (O.S.)
I saw your light on. Are you in any danger?

She tosses the tote-bag first, and watches it drop--three stories onto a dumpster lid.

She winces, then climbs out. Careful.

**EXT. PANTS'S APARTMENT (FRONT DOOR) - NIGHT**

Ritter looks at his watch, and sighs.

**EXT. PANTS'S APARTMENT (HANGING OUTSIDE WINDOW) - NIGHT**

Pants is dangling by her fingertips outside her window.

RITTER (O.S.)
Alright, well, if you're in there, Ms. Antsel, I'm going to leave my card under your door. You can call it whenever. Ask for Ritter, or my partner, Wilcox. Or just come in anytime.

We hear the footsteps on the stairs again, this time, walking away.

PANTS
(quiet, bitter)
Now I just feel *stupid*.

She strains to climb back in. The window slams shut on her fingertips. She lets go...

**EXT. OUTSIDE PANTS'S APARTMENT - NIGHT**

Ritter heads back to his Crown Vic. From behind him, we hear a BANG, then a soft THUD.

Ritter looks in the direction of the thud. He pauses. Listens. Narrows his eyes.

Then shakes his head and gets in the car, driving off.

**EXT. OUTSIDE PANTS'S APARTMENT (ALLEY) - NIGHT**

We see a dumpster with a severely dented lid. Next to it, Pants is flat on her back, lying next to her tossed clothes. Motionless. Eyes open.

She gasps. Still alive.

A moment. Then:

PANTS
(slow burn)
ooooooooowwww....

**INT. LVMPD EVIDENCE LOCKER - NIGHT**

Caleb moves through the evidence locker, searching.

SFX: A faint, discordant violin sting.

He suddenly whips his head around, his hand tightening. Instinct. Not conscious.

He exhales.

CALEB
A *bat-signal?* Already? How'd Pants hurt herself *already*?

He goes back to the search.

He finds her purse. Wallet with cash, cards, IDs. A phone in a black protective case with stickers on it, including a UAW-Local 3555 sticker. Pepper spray. Cereal bar. Tampon.

He takes the phone, leaves the rest in the purse, takes the purse with him.

He takes out a paper clip from his jacket, removes the phone's SIM card, drops it in the purse, keeps moving.

DVD-Rs, labeled in sharpie: “NORTH VEGAS HOSPITAL — MORGUE — CAM 3” “NORTH VEGAS HOSPITAL — MORGUE — CAM 3 (COPY?)” He grabs them.

Another purse. Another victim. He goes through it, but only to find the ID.

He turns on Pants's phone. It lights up. There's a missed call. A text preview: JANE: "where are u? getting worried. <frowny emoji>"

He ignores it. He just takes a picture of the ID with Pants's phone.

DUTCH ANGLE (V.O.)
Couldn't find my syringe, but I already had most of what I came for.
(beat)
The rest was just me cheating, cribbing answers off of the LVMPD's test.

SERIES OF SHOTS

- Surreal Item #1 - A slot-machine stool labeled: “URINE-SOAKED SLOT MACHINE STOOL”

- Caleb is taking photographs of any evidence related to the stalker case, in rapid succession. Other victim's belongings. One phone cracked, one pristine, both powered off, bagged. Wallets. IDs. DMV cards. A keychain with a novelty fob. Bagged clothing. Jeans. T-shirts. Bras (handled clinically). Shoes. Loose fibers. Hair. Lint. Carpet threads.

- Surreal Item #2: A Goku costume, clearly labeled as a biohazard. “COSTUME (DO NOT OPEN)”

- Printed reports. Caleb goes through, taking pictures. Call detail record summaries. Text message logs. Stapled.

- Surreal Item #3: A dead python. “PYTHON (LIVE AT TIME OF SEIZURE)”

- Caleb sees some cash from a busted drug deal, labeled $8,700 USD. He opens the bag. Sees the cash. Doesn't smile, doesn't hesitate. He peels off bills by feel.

A beat. He considers taking more. Doesn’t. He rebands the remaining stack neatly.

DUTCH ANGLE (V.O.) (cont'd)
Funny thing about stealing money. Take too much, and it screams. Take just enough, and it whispers. In Vegas, money never waits for an honest man.
(beat)
Besides. Theft was the least of my sins.

Caleb kneels, and slides Pants's purse through the bars of the evidence locker.

We PAN UP to the security camera.

A strip of duct tape seals the lens.

DUTCH ANGLE (V.O.) (cont'd)
I’ve made a lot of mistakes in my life.
(MORE)

DUTCH ANGLE (V.O.) (cont'd)
(beat)
I try not to make the same one twice.

**EXT. THE ORLEANS PARKING LOT - NIGHT**

Pants, shaken, pulls the Camry into the Orleans parking lot. Dash clock: 10:28.

She closes her eyes and leans back in exhaustion.

A knock on the window-- Caleb.

Pants unlocks the door, and he gets in the passenger side with her purse.

CALEB
Are you alright?

Pants doesn't answer. She eyes Caleb with her purse. Caleb eyes Pants with the new clothes.

CALEB (cont'd)
Stop by your place?

PANTS
(resigned)
Yep.

Caleb just sits there. Silence for a moment.

CALEB
Get what you need?

PANTS
Enough.

CALEB
Any trouble?

PANTS
I fell out a three story window onto a dumpster.

CALEB
Yeah, I thought it was something like that.

Pants turns her head, unsure what Caleb means.

CALEB (cont'd)
It's the sire-childe connection. Mutual danger-sense. Big trouble pings louder.

Pants makes a long, heavy sigh.

PANTS
Good to know.

CALEB
Works both ways, too. Angelina and I call it the Bat-Signal.

Pants slowly turns to Caleb to shoot him an exasperated look. Caleb looks at his watch.

CALEB (cont'd)
Change of plans. After that fall, you're running on fumes.

PANTS
Yeah, but where? Back to the haven?

CALEB
There's a place that's closer.
(beat)
You’re not going to like it.

**EXT. CARNICERIA - NIGHT**

It's the back of a family-run carniceria. The storefront is closed, but the lights are on in the back.

Pants is staying in the car, this time in the passenger seat.

One tired, apron-stained worker comes out with scraps, offcuts, and blood heavy trimmings in a wax-paper lined box. Caleb pays the man in cash.

He comes back to the car with the box, then slides it over to Pants.

CALEB
Bon Appetit.

Pants frowns, wrinkling her nose in disgust.

PANTS
Is this some kind of punishment?

CALEB
It's a learning experience. You got hurt. This is the fix.

PANTS
Oh.

Pants takes another sniff of the "meal," then tentatively starts feeding from it.

CALEB
It's important to keep topped up. You get too hungry, and you...

Caleb trails off.

CALEB (cont'd)
I don't know if you're ready to hear this.

PANTS
I'm probably not. But go ahead anyway.

CALEB
Blood bags. Animal blood. This. Better than nothing. Keeps you functional. Keeps you from going ravenous around people. Safer. Relatively.
(beat)
But it doesn't *sustain* you.
(beat)
That takes something else.

Pants looks at Caleb, horrified. She squirms, leans away from him.

PANTS
(quiet)
Live blood.

Caleb nods.

CALEB
Human.
(beat)
Everything else is just... empty calories. Starve to death without it.

Caleb shivers. A full body memory he can't suppress.

Pants pauses. Then goes back to the butcher's scraps.

**EXT. CARNICERIA - NIGHT - LATER**

Pants is still in the car, trying to finish the rest of the blood.

Caleb stands off to the side. Staring across the street.

We cut to his POV, he's looking at a tanning salon.

The neon flickers. Buzzes.

DUTCH ANGLE (V.O.)
The tanning salons. Always the tanning salons. I tell myself it's just a passing thought. But I know better.
(MORE)

DUTCH ANGLE (V.O.) (cont'd)
(beat)
Moths tell themselves the same thing right before the zap.

He looks over at the advertisement in the window. It reads: "Get a perfect suntan. 60,000 lux of UV light! Relax and let us do the work. Be radiant! Be you."

**INT. TANNING SALON - IMAGINED - NIGHT**

Caleb lowers himself into the tanning booth. The lid closes. Coffin-like. He's dead calm. Eyes closed. At peace.

DUTCH ANGLE (V.O.)
60,000 lux. Pure UV. *Bring it on*.

He turns the dial. Cranks it.

DUTCH ANGLE (V.O.) (cont'd)
Finally. Something bright in my future.

The bulbs ignite. A HUM. A SIZZLE. Smoke curls.

DING! The lid pops open. Reveals a charred skeleton in a denim jacket.

A faint draft. Ash lifts... clings to a Blockbuster card tucked in the jacket's front pocket, half-melted. What's left of the name: "Cal--".

**EXT. CARNICERIA - NIGHT**

Reality. Caleb is still standing behind the Carniceria. Same pose. Same stare.

He backs up. Shakes his head. Slaps himself. *Hard*.

CALEB
Stupid intrusive thoughts. That's *not helping*.

DUTCH ANGLE (V.O.)
But for a second, it felt like it might.

PANTS (O.S.)
(concerned)
Caleb?

Caleb looks back at Pants in the car. He starts to head back to her.

CALEB
Sorry. If you're done -- Orleans. Angelina.

Pants looks at the dashboard clock in the car.

PANTS
It's nearly midnight. Will she still be there?

CALEB
Should be. She works nights.

**EXT. OUTSIDE ORLEANS CASINO - NIGHT**

The Camry pulls in. They step out, heading for the entrance.

CALEB
Pants--casinos. You're still adjusting. Stick close.

PANTS
It's a *casino*, Caleb, how bad could it--

**INT. ORLEANS CASINO - NIGHT**

SMASH CUT. FLASH! Blinding LIGHTS! BLARE! Sudden CASINO NOISES. Cigar Smoke! WHOOSH! Arctic A/C. Elderly gamblers cling to slot machines like lifeboats. Cheers erupt at the craps table. A random howl echoes across the floor. No one looks up.

Pants freezes. Her breath goes shallow. Everything is *too loud*. Too *bright*. Too *close*. Too *Vegas*.

ANNOUNCER (V.O.)
Come celebrate 3-for-1 Mojito Mondays at Margarita Dave's-- where the alligator has now been *contained!*

A man in *Rainbow Dash pajamas* walks by, weeping into a piña colada. A bachelorette party drags a screaming bride across the floor. Security saws through fuzzy handcuffs linking a man to a railing--as he solemnly eats shrimp from a plastic champagne flute.

Beads land around Pants's neck.

PANTS
Who threw that!

We will never know.

Caleb scans the floor. Too many people. Too much noise. No clean exits.

CALEB
(checking in)
You good?

Pants doesn't respond right away.

Caleb turns back to check on her.

CALEB (cont'd)
Pants? Talk to me.

Pants shivers, then swallows. Forces air into her lungs.

PANTS
Worst Vegas trip since *Thompson*.
If the killer doesn’t get me,
this goddamn carpet pattern will
finish the job.

**INT. ORLEANS CASINO POKER ROOM - NIGHT**

The Orleans poker room hums with quiet intensity. Soft shuffling. Low murmurs. The occasional chip clack.

In the big blind, ANGELINA, (29, Staten Island accent), sits at a $2/5 table behind a stack of red and green chips. Calm. Focused. Unreadable. Clear cat-eye glasses instead of sunglasses.

DUTCH ANGLE (V.O)
Angelina. My greatest love. My
greatest regret. We were a
thing. I wrecked it.

She eyes the player on the BUTTON (male) across from her--tense, uncertain. There's five red chips ($25) in front of him.

She hasn’t moved. Absolute stillness.

DUTCH ANGLE (V.O.)
Those eyes. Total control.

Angelina peeks at her cards: *pocket kings*. *Black as death*.

Caleb and Pants enter. Pants still twitchy.

CALEB
Hey, Pants. Look around the
poker room. Try to guess which
one's Angelina.

Pants scans the tables-- Zeroes in *instantly*. Squints. Points.

PANTS
There. It's her. I don't know how I know. I just... do. Like... vampire gaydar.

CALEB
Quick learner. You're right.

Caleb looks over at Angelina and grimaces.

CALEB (cont'd)
Let's not bother her just yet. It looks like she's considering a big laydown. Queens. Maybe Kings.

PANTS
How can you read her hand from all the way over here? Who are you, *Daniel Nosferatu*?

CALEB
She doesn't have many tells. But I've seen that look before.

PANTS
What look?

Caleb gazes toward Angelina. Wistful. Quiet.

CALEB
The look of a woman who knows when it's the right play... to throw away a monster.

PANTS
(beat)
You mean *you*, don't you?

**INT. ORLEANS CASINO POKER ROOM - NIGHT (CONTINUOUS)**

Angelina's table. She eyes her opponent--*sweat bead, temple twitch, pulsing carotid, shrinking pupils*.

She glances at his chips. One and a half stacks of red, no greens.

ANGELINA
Nope. You've got aces.

She reveals her kings to the table.

ANGELINA (cont'd)
And you're not deep enough to set mine for the third king.

She mucks them. A fold.

The opponent looks gut-punched. Peeks at his *aces*, folds them face-down. Dealer slides him seven bucks.

Angelina smiles. Cool. Confident. Unbothered.

Caleb strides in. Pants twitches beside him.

DUTCH ANGLE (V.O.)
Yeah, she had the table right where she wanted them. And here I came to screw it all up.

Without turning around, Angelina *knows*.

ANGELINA
Go away, Caleb. You're bad luck.

CALEB
I thought you said poker was skill, not luck.

ANGELINA
I meant *generally*.

She turns. Sees Pants flinching at every sound--senses lit up like a fire alarm.

Angelina looks at Caleb. Her jaw tightens.

ANGELINA (cont'd)
Oh *no*, Caleb. You *didn't*.

Caleb looks away, can't meet Angelina's eyes.

Angelina starts racking up her chips. When she's done, she approaches Pants. Studies her.

Pants takes a half-step back, unsure.

ANGELINA (cont'd)
Hey. I'm Angelina. Name?

PANTS
Pants. Long story.

A jackpot blares. Pants jumps, then slumps. Angelina winces and places a steady hand on Pants's shoulder -- gentle, maternal.

ANGELINA
C'mon, Pants. Let's get you out of here. We'll go to my place. Quiet. Private. We'll talk.

**EXT. STORAGE LOCKERS - NIGHT**

A self-storage facility. Cursed Camry parked in front.

**INT. ANGELINA'S HAVEN - NIGHT**

We see as Angelina rolls up the aluminum door of a unit.

Reverse shot: Inside: Cheap but cheerful. Mildewed.

A queen bed. A battered brown suitcase peeks from underneath. A chest of drawers. A free-standing mirror. A wardrobe. A poster of New York City taped above the bed.

Compared to Caleb's hellhole, this is domestic. Barely. A place someone *could* live -- but no one should *have to*.

PANTS
This is... zoned for people?

ANGELINA
(sigh)
I know, right? Like an AirBnB in Pripyat. It beats Caleb's place out in the middle of nowhere.

PANTS
True.

CALEB
I *like* the middle of nowhere. The middle's the *best part* of the nowhere.

ANGELINA
Right. First...
(to Caleb)
*What the hell were you thinking?*

Caleb sighs, leaning against the wall. Pants sits down on the bed.

CALEB
She's the Stalker's latest victim. A witness.

PANTS
(incredulous)
"The *Stalker?*"

CALEB
It's a placeholder name.

ANGELINA
It's always a movie reference with you. What's this one, from Kolchak?

Pants looks between them, first at Caleb, then at Angelina, then back to Caleb.

PANTS
So, why are we here?

ANGELINA
Because Caleb's made a mess and he's come to me to clean it up.

Caleb winces.

CALEB
Not... entirely untrue, Angie. I need help managing this.

He gestures to Pants.

PANTS
(glaring)
*Manage* me?

CALEB
Not like that. It's just, I'm...

ANGELINA
You selfish, idiotic *prick*.

CALEB
I mean...

Angelina turns and advances on Caleb, fury restrained but very much present. Set jaw. Wide, angry eyes. A sneer.

ANGELINA
I can tell already. You're not treating her like a person. You're treating her like a *case*.

CALEB
Well I--

Angelina cuts Caleb off and turns to Pants.

ANGELINA
Pants, how long has it been?

PANTS
Last night.

ANGELINA
And in all that time, has he even asked you what *you* want to do? Let *you* make a real choice?

Pants sits up, angrily, finding steel.

PANTS
*No*. He *hasn't*.

CALEB
Whoa, hold on.

ANGELINA
She’s been dead less than two nights and you’re treating her like a puzzle piece.

Caleb gets angry and starts to snap back, stepping towards Angelina.

CALEB
Now wait a minute. I'm the only one here thinking clearly about this. The Stalker is the *real problem*. Pants could be key. I needed her for leverage.

From offscreen, a shoe goes flying and hits Caleb's head. It's Pants's shoe. We turn. She's got the other one ready to throw.

ANGELINA
Caleb, what the hell is *wrong with you?*

Caleb leans against the wall, sighs. That long, practiced sigh you earn from years of this shit.

Caleb gestures--frustrated, animated. His tone shifts. Slower. Bitter.

CALEB
What am I supposed to be doing? Preparing her for her *future?*
(beat)
Look around, Pants. This is the glamorous vampire life. No castles. No penthouses. Just an industrial park and a storage locker.

PANTS
Caleb. If being a vampire is so horrible, why. The *Fuck*. Did you do this to me?

Caleb's false bravado and detachment breaks. He shakes his head, paces... trying to steady himself before speaking--but it's *not* working.

CALEB
Because I thought maybe you could help! I didn't have time to weigh the ethics--I barely had time to think! It wasn't--

Caleb's voice cracks. He notices. He goes on anyway.

CALEB (cont'd)
--it wasn't fair that you were murdered! But you *were* and I couldn't stop it. And I'm sorry, okay? I tried--I tried *so fucking hard*.

PANTS
(cuts him off)
What am I supposed to do, Caleb? Help you play hero?

CALEB
Pants, there's someone else out there--another girl who doesn't know she's next! And if I don't stop this guy, she’s going to die!

Pants holds up her other shoe. She's about to throw it. But her hands are shaking.

She stops. Notices the shaking. Furious at it.

PANTS
No. No, no.
(beat)
Go stop him.

The words come out clean.

Her breathing doesn’t.

CALEB
(shocked)
What?

She presses her palms flat against the wall, grounding herself.

PANTS
What the *hell* are you doing here, getting me a *babysitter*, when my killer, *as you said*, is out there about to kill another young girl?

Pants gets up off the bed. She is *done with his bullshit*. She beats him with the shoe. Caleb flinches at each hit, not from the physical impact, but because it hurts emotionally.

PANTS (cont'd)
You want to play guilt-tormented vampire gumshoe? Fine. But turning me into a vampire so I’ll follow you around like some lovesick Bella Swan?
(MORE)

PANTS (cont'd)
(beat)
Reality check, Caleb. *You're no Angel*.

Caleb is about to *lose it*. Brows furrowed. A soft, almost imperceptible *hiss* growing in the back of his throat.

Angelina grabs him roughly and turns him, forcing him to face her -- not Pants.

ANGELINA
Caleb! You're *spiraling*. You're in *my house*, and you're being an ass. *Take a walk*.

CALEB
Angelina!

Angelina points to the door-- well, the rolling shutter.

ANGELINA
Take a *fucking walk*, Caleb! I'll handle the newbie.

Caleb grimaces.

DUTCH ANGLE (V.O.)
She wasn't just angry. She was right. I was spiraling like a roulette wheel. Red rage. Black despair.

Caleb looks away from Angelina, hanging his head.

DUTCH ANGLE (V.O.) (cont'd)
But Angelina bumped the wheel. Ball landed where it hurt the worst. Double zero. *Shame*.

He looks at Pants--just once. Then rolls up the shutter. And walks out.

**INT. STORAGE LOCKER HALLWAY - NIGHT**

We follow Caleb as he walks out. Pissed. Haunted. Alone. He stops for a moment. Then continues on.

DUTCH ANGLE (V.O.)
I waited for her to say: "You're better than this." She didn't.
(beat)
Guess she knew me better than I did.

**INT. LVMPD BUILDING - COLD CASE STORAGE - NIGHT**

Overhead fluorescent lighting. Clinical. Ritter is at a table, by a box labeled: "HOMICIDE 1998", and four file-folders. Thick. Each with a woman's name.

Wilcox steps in, offering a takeaway coffee from a place called "Grumpy John's." He's sipping one of his own. Ritter looks up to Wilcox. then at his (nice) watch.

RITTER
It's after midnight.

WILCOX
Stuff went missing from the evidence locker. IAB questioned everyone.

RITTER
That is going to fuck with chain of custody for *so* many cases. They catch 'im?

WILCOX
No.

Wilcox sits opposite Ritter, looking through what Ritter's pulled, as Ritter rubs his temples.

WILCOX (cont'd)
Parts of it felt amateur. Others felt like a pro. But the headline: He got away with some drug money from the Carson Street bust. About two thousand, not all of it. The rest?
(beat)
*All of it* had to do with the Antsel case.

Silent stare, as Wilcox sits down.

RITTER
All of it?

WILCOX
All of it except for the syringe we found at the crime scene -- that's still at the lab. It's what I mean. Pro -- got in, did the job, didn't get caught. Amateur -- made it obvious what he was going for. Cash might have just been a crime of opportunity.
(beat)
So, the files.

RITTER
Couldn't sleep. Had to check out a hunch. And then when I found this, my insomnia got worse.

Ritter hands over a photograph. Slight overexposure. Soft focus. Slight yellow warmth. It's clearly of Caleb. In his denim jacket.

The photo was taken during the *day*. *Sunlight* on his face. A *Zima* drink in hand. Payphone and Blockbuster in shot.

Wilcox studies it.

WILCOX
That photo's... old.
(beat)
You think this was Denim Jacket from the morgue tapes? Which... was one of the things taken, by the way.

RITTER
Yeah. But as I said, it's impossible.

WILCOX
Who is he?

RITTER
Suspect in a different serial case. Same kind of victims. M.O. isn't identical but close enough to bother me.
(beat)
Went missing in '98. Probate finalized in '03.
(beat)
A guy who's been dead for nearly twenty-five years just became our prime suspect.

WILCOX
What's his name?

RITTER
Calvin Trent.

On the table, the photo of "Calvin."

END OF PILOT